

Written for Lawyers or Users? Mapping the Complexity of Community Guidelines

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Abstract

Recent regulatory efforts such as the EU’s Digital Services Act aim to increase transparency in mostly opaque content moderation practices of social media platforms. They encourage platforms to post information about what content is prohibited on the platform. But what kinds of platforms follow these best practices, and how readable is the information posted for average users? This paper introduces the *Content Moderation Policies and Reports Dataset* (COMPARE), a new data collection comprising content moderation policies of 132 of the most popular social media platforms for comparative analysis. We then use COMPARE to measure the complexity of 89 community guidelines, focusing on length, readability, and semantic complexity. We find that while the largest platforms are most likely to make guidelines available, they also tend to have the longest and semantically most complex guidelines. In addition, community guidelines seem to grow in length with new regulation. Our results suggest that it is crucial to look beyond the mere provision of community guidelines and to study how complex guidelines are for users.

Introduction

Social media was once considered a vehicle for enhancing the democratic process by promising to empower users to participate in online discussions while bypassing traditional media gatekeepers. Yet, over time, their democratic potential has been overshadowed by the emergence of more troubling aspects (Tucker et al. 2017). Content such as hate speech and misinformation can pose challenges to democratic governance by decreasing trust in politicians, fostering polarization, and producing misinformed voters (Jerit and Zhao 2020; Tucker et al. 2018; Lorenz-Spreen et al. 2023). While the evidence on their effects is mixed, social media has also been weaponized by actors with malicious intentions through foreign influence campaigns (Eady et al. 2023; Pierri et al. 2023). To counter this and other potentially harmful content, platforms often aggressively moderate content on their platforms. By becoming “the arbitrators for what is and what is not allowed in the public sphere” (Maddox and Malson 2020, p. 3), platforms hold tremendous power. However, public trust in those platforms is low, with surveys revealing that three-quarters of Americans do

not trust social media companies to make fair content moderation decisions (Kamp and Ekins 2021).

To maintain platform discretion over the moderation of content while also addressing the problem of public trust, scholars, public officials, and civil society activists have advocated for more transparency in content moderation. As part of this, many have argued that social media companies should provide community guidelines to users that outline the applicable rules of engagement on a platform (MacCarthy 2020; Suzor et al. 2019; European Union 2022; Access Now et al. 2018; Electronic Frontier Foundation et al. 2015). A community guidelines document is published and updated by the platform; it “lays out the platform’s expectations of what is appropriate and what is not. It also announces the platform’s principles, and lists prohibitions, with varying degrees of explanation and justification” (Gillespie 2019, p. 46). Proposed standards for these guidelines, such as those put forward by civil society organizations in the Santa Clara Principles, urge platforms to “publish clear and precise rules and policies relating to when action will be taken with respect to users’ content or accounts” (Access Now et al. 2018). While the Digital Services Act (DSA) does not mention community guidelines directly, Article 14 requires platforms to provide “information on any restrictions that they impose in relation to the use of their service” in their terms and conditions. In addition, it mandates that the terms and conditions “shall be set out in clear, plain, intelligible, user-friendly and unambiguous language” (European Union 2022).

While posting community guidelines has become a common practice for most social media platforms, very little work has studied how accessible they are to users and their differential use across platforms. Achieving transparency through community guidelines requires that users can clearly understand what behavior is admissible and what is prohibited. However, there are vast differences in the way that community guidelines are presented across platforms. Our comparative analysis aims to study this variation empirically. Focusing on 132 social media platforms, we ask:

- **RQ1:** What are the characteristics of social media platforms that publish community guidelines compared to those that do not?
- **RQ2:** What is the complexity of the guidelines in terms of length, readability, and semantic complexity?